

The Quaker

March



The Quaker: This illustrates two common tendencies, the first for pipers to refer to a tune by the briefest of possible titles so that longer titles get collapsed into a simple tag, and, secondly, for a common pool of musical ideas to be distributed amongst various instruments and genres.

The present tune seems to be a cut-down version of “Merrily Danced the Quaker’s Wife” (first published by Robert Bremner in 1759) which has various sets of words to it, and is also a country dance. It demonstrates that a melody need not be weakened by being re-arranged to accommodate the nine note scale of the pipe chanter. There is a four parted version in Logan, and also in Glen’s *Highland Bagpipe Music* (the third and fourth parts being marked “by D. G.”. Glen part 9 was published in 1892 and the relevant Logan volume in 1906. There is a four-parted version of the tune in Donald MacLeod’s collection bk. 5, but I prefer the two-parted setting given here.

There have been Quakers in Scotland since the 17th century and the North East was one of their important centres. In Aberdeen they bore the brunt of official persecution which inspired Robert Barclay of Urie, near Stonehaven, to his classic assertion of Quaker principles, *Apology for the True Christian Divinity* (1678) which has been seldom out of print since. After his son John emigrated to America, Robert Barclay accepted the governorship of East New Jersey, although he remained in Aberdeen, promoting emigration of Quakers from the North East.